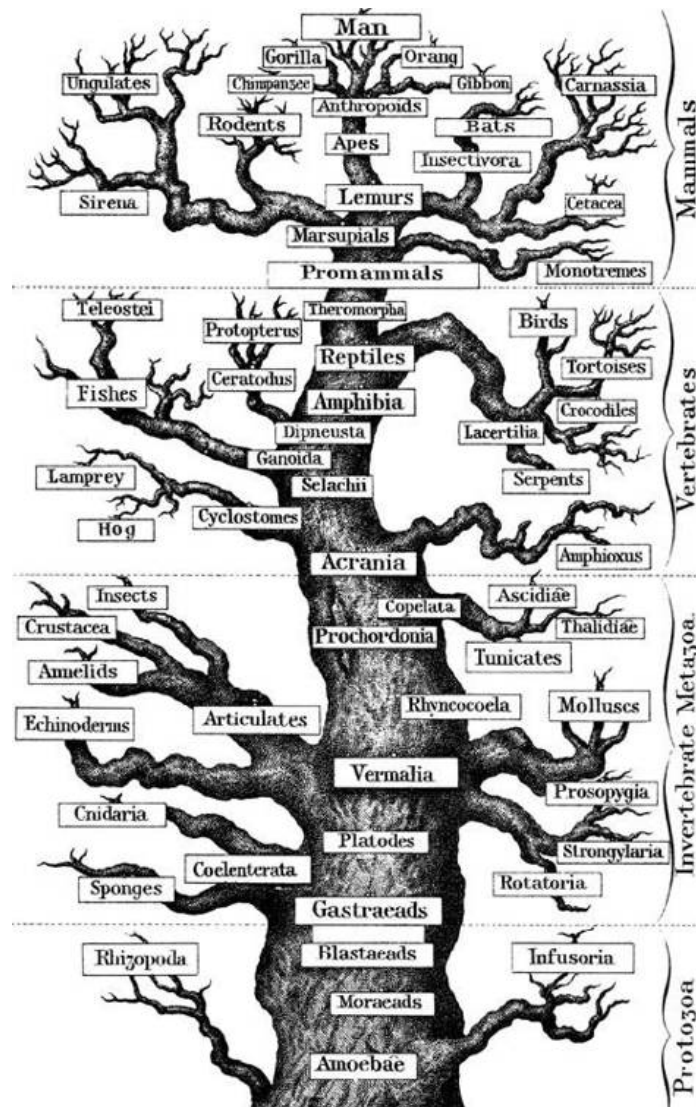


Reality as a perpetual flow



Henri Bergson was deeply influenced by Darwin's theory of evolution, and believed that humans and the world they live in can be understood as part of the evolutionary process. Like Heraclitus (see [Heraclitus: everything is in flux](#)), he saw reality as a continuous flow: everything is constantly changing and evolving, and the flow of time is fundamental to all reality. As a part of this continuum, we experience it directly, not through our senses or ideas, and the flow of time and our inner experience of it are the same thing. Bergson identified this with the *élan vital* (life force) that he believed drove the process of evolution. In contrast, our perceptions are determined by

evolution, and our senses are not there to provide us with ideas about the world, but to aid us in our survival. As such, they only tell us what we need to know for survival and do not give an objective picture of the world. We therefore have an incomplete knowledge of the world around us, a relative knowledge from our unique perspective, as compared with the absolute knowledge through direct intuition of the continuum of reality.